whether a united Western Europe will be an ally or become a competitor of the United States. Although the United States at present seems to be the unchallenged power, there are also several power centres and the international system tends to become multipolar. Therefore, the functioning of the balance of power system in such a multipolar world cannot be ruled out completely. As US Secretary of State, Lawrence Eagleburger proclaimed in 1989 that “We are now moving into… a world in which power and influence [are] diffused among a multiplicity of states – [a] multipolar world”. Scholars suggest that such multipolar system is more likely to consist of the United States, China, Germany, Japan, Russia and a consolidated European Union. They envisage that such multipolarity will result in an enlarged global chessboard of multiple bilateral geo-strategic relationships.[19]